‘No, I need a safe house in Sydney,’ Malik said. ‘I also require your help with assets in Fiji. I believe you already know about the situation.’

Forty-five-year-old Cooper, born in Canberra, Australia, had inherited a sugar business from his father Oliver Cooper in the early 1980s. The senior Cooper had a limited line of sugar exports from Fiji to the UK. But Samuel Cooper had his eye on all of Europe.

During a dinner at the Australian embassy in London sometime in 1982, he had met Malik, a junior Indian diplomat. Malik promised to help Cooper however he could. In the next few months, Malik introduced Cooper to several import houses in Europe. Cooper’s trust in Malik was organic and soon they became good friends. Good enough for Malik to reveal the true nature of his work.

‘I’ll repay you someday,’ Cooper had told Malik when he opened a branch office of his business in London in 1983. The time had come to pay his debt.

‘It will be done. Give me a few weeks. When are you planning to visit Sydney?’ asked Cooper as he enjoyed his sumptuous meal.

‘Next week. Can you also put me in touch with someone in Wellington?’

Cooper was silent for a moment. ‘I think I can, but be careful, you are playing a dangerous game.’

That evening, Malik had a heavily-coded conversation with Sanjiv Sahgal, the second member of the band of three, who was in Delhi. Sahgal was told to prepare for a trip to Wellington, the